B 4 F C

Pre-Leaving Certificate Examination, 2025

English – Ordinary Level – Paper 1
(Option A)

Total Marks: 200

Time: 2 hours 50 minutes

- This paper is divided into two sections.
  Section I COMPREHENDING and Section II COMPOSING.
- The paper contains **three** texts on the general theme of **JOURNEYS.**
- Candidates should familiarise themselves with each of the texts before beginning their answers.
- Both sections of this paper (COMPREHENDING and COMPOSING) must be attempted.
- Each section carries 100 marks.

SECTION I – COMPREHENDING

- Two Questions, A and B, follow each text.
- Candidates must answer a Question A on one text and a Question B on a different text. Candidates must answer only one Question A and only one Question B.
- **N.B.** Candidates may NOT answer a Question A and a Question B on the same text.

SECTION II – COMPOSING

- Candidates must write on **one** of the compositions 1 – 7.

SECTION I COMPREHENDING (100 marks)

TEXT 1 – AUSTRALIA: A NEW PLACE TO LIVE

TEXT 1 is based on an article in *The Irish Times* by Laura Kennedy, originally entitled "Laura Kennedy: You can't escape yourself abroad, but you can find someone you're less eager to escape from." In the article, she reflects on a major life journey – moving to Australia. It was published in July 2024.

1. You can't escape yourself. There's an ominous opening line for you. I don't mean it as a threat, the way the nuns who taught me at school meant it when they said that "God sees everything." I mean it in the sense that we all have a friend or acquaintance who went traveling to "find themselves" and came back with no discernible alteration apart from a farmer's tan and a new taste for wearing beads, which may or may not be seen as cultural appropriation depending on who you ask. Whether it is or not, you can't be wearing beads in Limerick or Cavan or Trim and talking about the wisdom gleaned on your travels (two months in your friend Sarah's studio flat in Melbourne, plus a week in India) and expect not to be reminded where you came from. Fierce notions altogether.

2. Since moving to Australia almost a year ago, however, I have discovered that the nuns were incorrect in some ways. Not all your problems follow when you run away. Almost 11 months into my time here, I'm still very much the same person. No farmer's tan, because exposing a Celtic complexion to Australian sun is a bit like taking a belt sander to a leather sofa. You do lie to yourself a good deal prior to emigration, imagining versions of yourself who might do things you'd never, ever do at home, such as taking a cheesemaking course or going truffle hunting or not waiting until the last minute to file your tax return. Perhaps in Australia I would become magically extroverted and bubbly after a lifetime of being precisely the opposite. Perhaps I would become a hiker, taking to the famed nature reserves here in Canberra with a good pair of boots and a new appetite for adventure.

3. Maybe in Australia I would become infinitely healthier and decide that actually cake is horrible and I've never cared for it myself. I'd only eat avocados and tropical fruits and whatever their version of cod is here – I haven't quite been able to figure it out.

4. The act of leaving and beginning again opens a new plain of possibility before you. Suddenly, you land in a place where people have no fixed idea of who you are. They don't remember that your hair always smelled like cat food in your teens no matter how much you washed it. They weren't present when you burst your shorts in an unfortunate senior hurling match incident, long since known in your town as 'arsing Sunday'. Nobody here calls you Jean-Paul Sartre because you had the boldness to wear a scarf into the pub one Baltic December night 15 years ago. When you emigrate, you shed the version of yourself that others consider to be who you are and what you're left with is an intoxicating, intimidating vastness of potential.

5. Australia has changed me. There are elements of yourself that you take to be inherent and then realise, once in a new environment, aren't necessarily so. I'm far more active here than I was in Dublin or London – it turns out it simply is objectively easier and more pleasurable to move your body when it's bright outside, temperatures are milder and you don't work late every night. What was a constant battle with myself at home, frequently featuring negative self-judgment (you lazy waste of . . . etc.) has become more pleasurable.

6. Australia also hasn't changed me. I still like cake, for one thing, and they have lamingtons here – little cubes of buttery sponge dipped in a chocolatey glaze type affair and then rolled in coconut. I tried one with jam in it recently and it would take the legs from under you.

7. This, I think, is one of the lovelier elements of emigrating (and I don't just mean the joys of foreign cake, though there's that too). You

learn to see yourself as a product of different environments and that you can be different depending on where you find yourself. It shows you that there are many potential ways you might live your life, and that each new place brings with it a lifestyle that may show you something new about yourself as well as the world.

8. Who we are here and now can change in unanticipated ways if we relocate. We can't escape ourselves but we can improve ourselves. We can learn which parts of us are changeable, and which are less so. We might even find a self we're less eager to escape from.

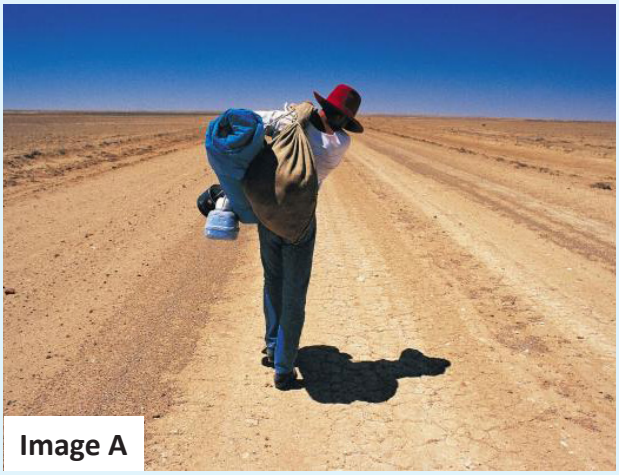

Image A

Image B

This text has been adapted, for the purpose of assessment, without the author's prior consent.

N.B. Answer ONLY ONE Question A and ONLY ONE Question B.

Question A – 50 marks

(i) Based on your reading of the written part of TEXT 1, what impression do you form of the author, Laura Kennedy? Make three points in your response. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) Do you think this article is well written? Give reasons for your answer, referring to the above extract. (15)

(iii) (a) The theme of this paper is 'Journeys'. What do you think has been an important journey in your life? Explain why you think this journey was so important. (10)

(b) Imagine that **one** of the two images accompanying this text is to be included with the article in a magazine in order to make the piece more appealing to readers. Which one of the images would you choose to include with the article? Give reasons for your answer, referring to **both** images in your response. (10)

Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

Question B – 50 marks

Imagine you are conducting a **radio interview**, speaking with an adventurer who has just completed an incredible journey. Write the **text** of the radio interview, including the responses that you think the interviewee might give. In the interview you should ask them: to outline their incredible journey, to pick and describe a highlight and a low point from the journey, and to offer one piece of advice for listeners who may be thinking about completing their own incredible journeys.

TEXT 2 – RUNNING THE LENGTH OF AFRICA

TEXT 2 is based on an article in *The Guardian* by Caroline Davies, originally entitled "'I'm a little bit tired': Briton becomes first person to run the length of Africa". In this article, she writes about Russ Cook, an English man who became the first person to run the entire length of the African continent in April 2024. It was originally published in April 2024.

1. After more than 9,940 miles (16,000km) over 352 days across 16 countries, Russ Cook, aka the "Hardest Geezer," has completed the mammoth challenge of running the length of Africa. The 27-year-old endurance athlete from Worthing, West Sussex, crossed the finish line in Tunisia on Sunday afternoon and planned to celebrate with a party – as well as a strawberry daiquiri (a type of cocktail) – having raised more than £600,000 for charity.

2. His achievement, believed to be the first person to run tip to tip from southern to northern Africa, was the more extraordinary given several setbacks including a robbery at gunpoint in Angola, being held by men with machete blades in the Republic of the Congo, health scares, and visa complications. On 22 April 2023, he set off from South Africa's most southerly point, Cape Agulhas. By the time he crossed the line at Tunisia's most northerly point, Ras Angela, he had run the distance of about 376 marathons.

3. Cook was accompanied on the final leg by supporters who had flown out after following his journey on social media, as he documented his odyssey on X, Instagram, and YouTube, with posts amassing millions of views. He finished to cheers of "Geezer, Geezer" and took a well-deserved dip in the sea, telling Sky News: "I'm a little bit tired." On the eve of his final leg, Cook told Sky News: "It's quite hard to put into words: 352 days on the road, a long time without seeing my family, my girlfriend, my body is in a lot of pain but one more day, I'm not about to complain."

4. Money raised will go to the Running Charity, which provides running and mental health programmes to young people experiencing homelessness and complex needs, and Sandblast, which promotes awareness of the Saharawi people. During Cook's feat, he ran through rainforests, across mountain ranges, and traversed the Sahara. On day 200, he reduced his daily mileage on doctors' advice in Nigeria. "I took a couple of days to get some scans. No bone damage so figured the only option left was to stop mincing about like a little weasel, get the strongest painkillers available and zombie stomp the road again," he said at the time.

5. Visa problems getting into Algeria were overcome after his appeal video on X was seen by 11 million people and the Algerian embassy in the UK announced he would be given a courtesy visa. He was due to celebrate with a finish-line party at a hotel in Bizerte, Tunisia. "Get your daiquiris ready, girls and boys, this is gonna be mega," he wrote. Before setting off on his challenge, Cook revealed he wanted to make a difference, saying: "I'm a totally normal bloke, so if I can do this, hopefully people can apply this to their own lives in whichever way they choose. For 99% of people, it's not going to be running across Africa, but it might look like chasing their dreams a little bit more." He has called the challenge "the toughest in my life but an immense honour," adding: "We have met incredible people in every single country we've been to that have welcomed us with love and kindness. The human spirit is a beautiful thing."

6. Cook is not new to challenges: previous ones have included running from Istanbul to London, being buried alive for a week, and the fastest marathon pulling a car. Alex Eagle, a friend and the co-founder of the Running Charity, where Cook worked as an adventure coach for young people before embarking on Project Africa, told the Guardian when Cook first suggested the African odyssey, "obviously it was outlandish, but we all thought he could do it."

7. "He is a determined man, and he's a man that has overcome things like a lot of the young people that we work with have overcome difficult challenges in their lives," he added. Eagle did worry at times for Cook going into the unknown, but whenever they spoke he was "positive, always positive, always one step

ahead in the moment, really grateful for the experience, really grateful for the people he's met… That is his personality."

8. "If you are squeamish, the images of his feet are quite horrific at times," Eagle added. Of the challenges, he said: "The scale of it. You hear it, but you don't really comprehend it. He's just consistently been able to bring his mind to it, to get up every day and do that. It's just awe-inspiring." The charity plans a group run on his return and Cook will also be running the London Marathon with young people from the charity. "I think that will be a walk in the park for him," Eagle said.

Image A

Image B

This text has been adapted, for the purpose of assessment, without the author's prior consent.

N.B. Answer ONLY ONE Question A and ONLY ONE Question B.

Question A – 50 marks

(i) Based on your reading of the written part of TEXT 2, what impression do you form of Russ Cook? Make three points in your response. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) Do you think this article gives a good sense of the difficulty of completing this journey from the bottom to the top of Africa? Give reasons for your answer, referring to the above extract. (15)

(iii) (a) The theme of this paper is 'Journeys'. What do you think has been an important journey in your life? Explain why you think this journey was so important. (10)

(b) Imagine that **one** of the two images accompanying this text is to be included with the article in a magazine in order to make the piece more appealing to readers. Which one of the images would you choose to include with the article? Give reasons for your answer, referring to **both** images in your response. (10)

Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

Question B – 50 marks

In TEXT 2, Russ Cook encourages people to "chase their dreams". Write the text of a **talk**, to be delivered to a group of young people beginning their secondary school education, about the importance of chasing your dreams. In your talk, you should: describe a dream or goal you had as a younger person, outline the extent to which you have fulfilled that dream or goal, and give advice on how best to go about achieving one's dreams or goals in life.

TEXT 3 – LEAVING THE CAR BEHIND TO WALK THROUGH FRANCE

TEXT 3 is an extract from a series of articles in *GQ* magazine by the travel writer Elizabeth Gilbert describing her journey by foot along a walking route in the French countryside. It was published in June 2009.

1. The small, picturesque town of Fontaine-de-Vaucluse sits in a valley, surrounded by beautiful scenery. This meant that our departure the next morning would involve a climb. To prepare, we indulged in a feast the night before, enjoying escargots, oysters, anchovies, veal's head, and numerous bottles of Côtes du Luberon wine. The next morning, we packed our belongings and set off, bid farewell by the elegant hotel proprietor who joked about using a Mercedes or a helicopter for such a long journey. But for us, walking was the only option.

2. It took us some time to get used to walking the GR-6 walking trail, which wasn't as well marked as we had hoped. We were alone on the path, unable to rely on fellow hikers for guidance, and often had to consult our compass. Despite these challenges, we quickly realised how much we loved it. Walking allowed us to experience the country intimately, encountering everything from iris blossoms and local wildlife to the scents of cow pastures, mustard fields, and wild herbs.

3. The trail we followed was historically significant, having been used for centuries by people travelling between Fontaine-de-Vaucluse and Gourds for various purposes. This connection to history made us feel like simple peasants, though the memory of our decadent meal often shattered this illusion. Walking like modest serfs by day and dining like royalty by night became the beautiful contradiction of our journey.

4. The next day, we continued through the countryside, stopping at a local market to buy a simple lunch of baguette and water. However, we couldn't resist adding a wheel of Camembert, a bottle of red wine, local pâté, and a slice of rillettes (fat preserved meats) to our meal. One reason for this trip was the theory that walking would offset our indulgences, but we soon realized that our daily walks weren't enough to burn off all the calories we consumed.

5. The true joy of our trip came from the close, unguarded experience of France we had by walking. Without the protection of steel or gears, we encountered an unpretentious, welcoming version of the country. Walking trails led us past homes, farms, vineyards, and footbridges. We interacted with livestock, chatted with children, and observed everyday life, like an old man pruning grapevines or a woman washing dishes while her child practised piano scales. These moments were like living in a Vermeer painting, complete with fragrance and sound.

6. We often picnicked in quiet ditches near lavender fields, preferring the outdoors to restaurants for lunch. Our backpacks carried baguettes and bottles of wine, allowing us to enjoy leisurely meals in nature. Once, we dined by a stream, cooling our feet in the water as we shared our food. These picnics became the highlight of our daily routine, and we often fell asleep afterward.

7. The slow pace of walking, talking, eating, drinking, and napping brought a sense of balance and recalibration. I felt like I had caught up with time, experiencing each day as if it had the exact right number of hours. As my companion put it, "For the first time in my life, every single day seems to have the exact right number of hours in it." This journey allowed us to connect deeply with the landscape and the people, making it a truly transformative experience.

This text has been adapted, for the purpose of assessment, without the author's prior consent.

N.B. Answer ONLY ONE Question A and ONLY ONE Question B.

Question A – 50 marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 3, what impression do you form of Elizabeth Gilbert? Make three points in your response. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) Do you think this article gives a good sense of the benefits of walking through the French countryside rather than driving? Give reasons for your answer, referring to the above extract. (15)

(iii) (a) The theme of this paper is 'Journeys'. What do you think has been an important journey in your life? Explain why you think this journey was so important. (10)

(b) Imagine you have been tasked with adding **two** new images to accompany this article. Describe the images you would add and explain why you believe these would be good additions to accompany the article. (10)

Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

Question B – 50 marks

Imagine you own a holiday company called Big Foot Holidays which specialises in organising walking holidays. Write a **promotional article**, to be published online, advertising tours organised by your company. In your promotional article, you should: describe how the idea for starting the company originated, outline a number of walking holidays offered by your company, and explain a variety of benefits to walking holidays.

B 4 F C

SECTION II COMPOSING (100 marks)

Write a composition on **any one** of the following composition assignments in **bold print** below.

Each composition carries 100 marks.

The composition assignments are intended to reflect language study in the areas of information, argument, persuasion, narration, and the aesthetic use of language.

1. In TEXT 1, Laura Kennedy states, 'you can't escape yourself'.

Write a short story in which a character attempts to escape significant danger.

2. In TEXT 1, Laura Kennedy states, 'Australia has changed me'.

Write a personal essay in which you reflect on the impact a place has had on you.

3. In TEXT 2, Russ Cook is described as having travelled through challenging landscapes, such as rainforests, mountains and deserts.

Write a short story that includes a difficult journey through a challenging landscape in search of a rare object.

4. In TEXT 2, Russ Cook states that he is 'a totally normal bloke'.

Write an article for publication in a popular magazine about embracing difference in people. Your article can be serious or amusing or both.

5. In TEXT 3, Elizabeth Gilbert states, 'I felt like I had caught up with time'.

Write the text of a speech to be delivered to a group of young people about the importance of slowing down and living in the moment.

6. In TEXT 3, Elizabeth Gilbert states that on one day, she 'stopped at a local market to buy a simple lunch of baguette and water'.

Write a short story, set in a market, in which a character eats an unusual meal.

7. In TEXT 3, Elizabeth Gilbert states, 'these picnics became the highlight of our daily routine'.

Write a personal essay about simple pleasures that make up part of your daily and/or weekly routine.